

Features

In terms of features, the iP1000 surprised us: it does not even ship with an output tray! This seems to be a trend now, since the 1500 didn't ship with one either. Thankfully, the other manufacturers were more considerate, and squeezed in an output tray.

All the printers came with a black and a colour cartridge. None of them came with PictBridge or automatic double-sided printing or the ability to print CD or DVDs, but hey, there's only so much you can get for Rs 4000! And if you really look at it, who doesn't mind saving a few thousand rupees and spending some extra time to print pictures through your PC rather than straight from your PictBridge printers (read costly printers)? Plus, you get the added ability to tweak them via Photoshop!

The Epson Stylus C45 and HP DeskJet 3845 looked really sturdy and sleek and rated high on build quality. The iP1000 was the worst looking with a pale grey finish, and none of the class exuded by its bigger brothers, or indeed, any of its peers in this segment.

Performance

After our initial tryst with it, our expectations had lowered considerably as far as the iP1000 was concerned. But we soon realised that it was a mistake to judge the book by its cover—in the case of the iP1000, by the lack of a tray!

The test results surprised us so much, we conducted them twice! Twenty-two pages of our drain test document utilised a mere 10 per cent of its ink. We tested it for printing speed, and it left the others behind, printing our test document in 10 seconds flat.

The second-fastest printer was the HP 3745 at 16 seconds; 17 for the HP 3845. We then took an enforced break; we figured it was a better idea to have a cuppa tea as the Epson C45 printed the page, taking 35 seconds! The HP 3845 printed just two pages with 10 per cent of its ink. The figures for the HP 3845 and Epson C45 were seven and 10 pages respectively.

For our quality tests, we took pure text documents printed in B&W mode with the print quality set to Normal. The quality of the text printouts was largely the same, with the iP1000 giving us the crispest and cleanest results followed by the HP 3745. The Epson C45 had some trouble—we could

The cost of home printers today may be low, but they are pretty high on performance

discern a few cracks in the letters. We assumed that at home, you would want to print school projects or even presentations. So, we created a document, affectionately called 'combi-doc', consisting of text, a pie-chart and various graphics and photos, and tested the printers for speed and quality. The Canon iP1000 again boomed ahead, printing the combi-doc in 50 seconds; the HP 3845 came a distant second with 66 seconds, while the 3745 took 76 seconds. The Epson C45 brought up the rear with a ridiculous 127.7 seconds!

In terms of quality of the printout, HP 3745 was snapping at the Canon iP1000's heels. The Epson C45 was a let-down again—it took forever to print the document, and did a really bad job of it.

As Canon claims—Pixma is all about fast image printing, we verified the marketing mumbo jumbo. We printed the image at the highest quality settings.

Well, this time, it wasn't just mumbo jumbo. The Canon iP1000 truly outclassed the other printers, printing the A4-sized document in 185 seconds, while the count was 592 seconds for the HP 3845 and 625 seconds for the HP 3745. And yes, we also tested the Epson C45, but we took a lunch break this time—it took 1179 seconds! That's almost 20 minutes!

In terms of quality of the photo, the iP1000 really made an impression—not only did it hammer its rivals, it even managed to keep up with our more expensive photo printers! So, if you want cheap high quality printing, get this before it goes out of stock! The HP 3745 had better quality, but was a touch slower; the HP 3845 was the exact opposite—it was faster than the HP 3745 but was wanting in terms of quality. The Epson C45 matched the HP 3845 in terms of quality, but it also took twice the time.

So, if you want good quality photos in a reasonable amount of time, opt for Canon iP1000. If you want to print anything with good quality and great speed, the iP1000 is the way to go.

Conclusion

There's no doubt about the winner here. The Canon Pixma iP1000 was the fastest, and the best printer in every aspect of our tests in the sub-Rs 4000 category.



Epson Stylus C45

We explored the overflooded market of inkjet printers and MFDs to bring you a blow-by-blow account of how they fared, and what you should use until that dream of a paperless office becomes a reality—if it ever does!

INKJET PRINTERS Home Printers

The printers that featured in the tests were in two categories: Home and Office/Photo printers, based on price. Initial price and running costs are a more telling factor than raw speed and performance, so they were accorded a higher weightage. Home printers were identified as devices available for Rs 4,000 or less. Printers falling into this category are the Canon iP1000, the Epson Stylus C45, and the HP DeskJet 3745 and 3845.